refutation by the Chinese paper *Global Times* !

Rabindranath Tagore's visit to China in 1924 has been described as a milestone in India–China relations. The suggestion that it rekindled a sense of affinity between the peoples of the two countries and promoted solidarity in their struggle against Western imperialism is an exaggeration. Tagore may have been received with polite courtesy and enjoyed respect as a Nobel laureate, but his notions of a rejuvenated Eastern civilization prevailing over a materialistic and spiritually bankrupt West found no resonance in China. Eastern civilization, as the Chinese saw it, did not include India, though perhaps it could include Japan. Left-wing intellectuals such as Lu Xun, Guo Moruo, Shen Yanbing, Chen Duxiu and Qu Qiubai were all critical of Tagore's ideas even though they admired his scholarship and poetry. Shen Yanbing said:

> We are determined not to welcome the Tagore who loudly sings the praises of Eastern civilisation, nor do we welcome the Tagore who creates a paradise of poetry and love and leads our youth into it so that they might find comfort and intoxication in meditating. [5]

Qu Qiubai was more even more dismissive, describing Tagore as a man of the past whose advice was irrelevant. The claim made by the Japanese scholar Shigenobu Okura had greater resonance among the Chinese, when he said:

> Of the nations of Asian civilisation today, I consider Japan to be the greatest. Next is China. As for the people of Babylon and India, even though their cultures could be admired in bygone days, now they cannot even be compared. [6]

The Chinese audience might have contested the Japanese claim to be number one, but would not have disagreed with the proposition on India.

Individual Chinese interactions with Indians sometimes produced a more favourable impression among them of the latter. Zhang Taiyan became interested in Buddhism during the three years he spent in prison in Japan. His extended conversations with an Indian friend in Tokyo led him to believe that Indians and the Hans should work in solidarity to rid their peoples of British and Manchu alien rule, and that China could draw inspiration from India's own struggle for freedom. There were other Chinese individuals who were deeply influenced by Tagore and accepted his invitation to live and teach at Santiniketan. They included well-known